

Web Design and Interactive Publishing

The web as a publishing medium



What this course builds

A semester of deliberate web publishing

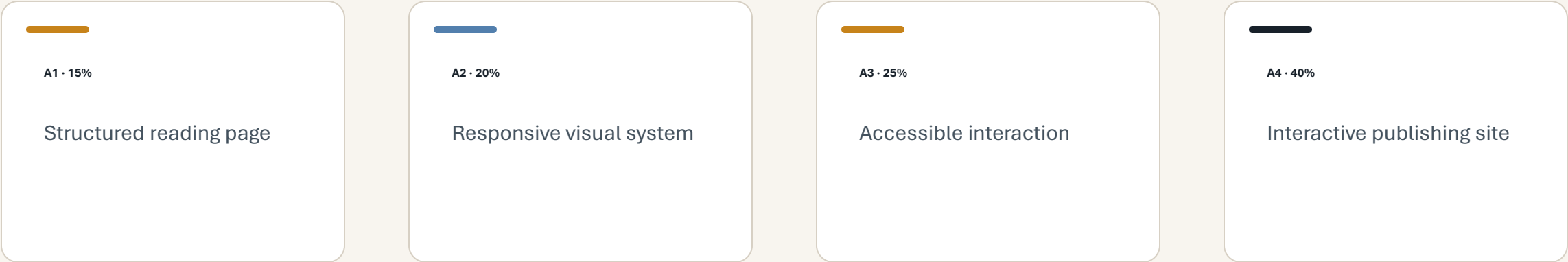
Semantic HTML, visual hierarchy, responsive CSS, accessible interaction, testing and revision.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Assessment map

Four connected projects, 100% total



Assignment 1

Structured reading page · 15%

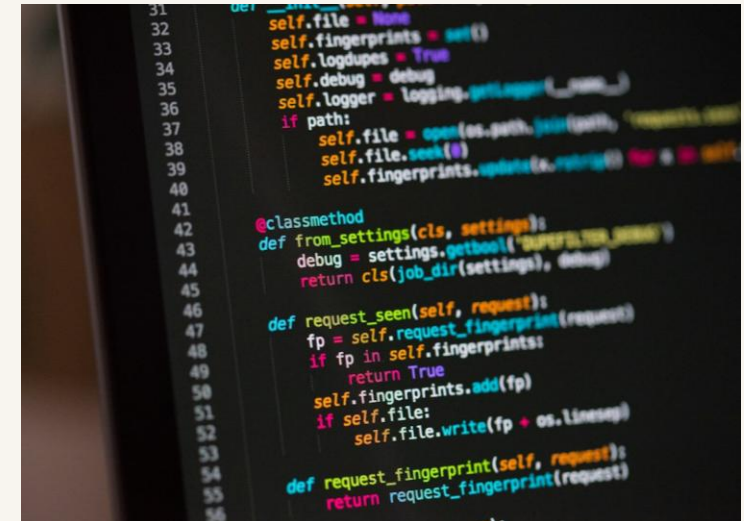
Build a semantic one-page reading experience. Show heading hierarchy, meaningful links and text alternatives.

Assignment 2

Responsive visual system · 20%

Turn content into a type, spacing, colour and layout system that works at narrow and wide sizes.

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Assignment 3

Accessible interaction prototype · 25%

Build a focused task flow with keyboard access, labels, errors and visible feedback.

Assignment 4

Interactive publishing site · 40%

Create a small multi-page site with information architecture, shared navigation, testing evidence and a process dossier.

Week 1 outcomes

What you should be able to do today

Describe the difference between content, structure, presentation and behaviour. Inspect a page before changing it.

Question

What evidence would let you judge this page?

Evidence

Name a specific heading, control, label or reading path.

A webpage is a document

The browser needs structure before it can render design

HTML expresses what each part means. CSS controls how it looks. JavaScript changes behaviour when a task needs it.

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The publishing question

Who needs this page, and what should they understand or do?

A page with no clear audience often accumulates features. A page with a task can make choices about hierarchy.

Reading paths

A visitor rarely reads from top to bottom

They scan headings, links, images and the first line of paragraphs. Design should support a useful path, not demand attention.

Content before components

Start with the material

Write a title, summary, sections, evidence, next action and source information before choosing a card, carousel or animation.

Semantic HTML

Elements carry meaning

Use headings for hierarchy, paragraphs for prose, lists for groups, nav for navigation and buttons for actions.

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HTML anatomy

A minimal, meaningful document

```
<main>
  <article>
    <h1>How to repair a bicycle light</h1>
    <p>A practical guide for first-time riders.</p>
  </article>
</main>
```

Read code aloud: element, content, relationship and purpose.

Heading hierarchy

Headings form an outline, not a font-size menu

One page normally has one h1. Use h2 for major sections and h3 only inside an h2 section.

A useful outline

Structure makes the page navigable

h1: Community garden guide

h2: Before you visit

h2: What to bring

h2: Find a plot

h3: Weekday access

h3: Weekend access

Landmarks

Landmarks let assistive technology jump through a page

header, nav, main, aside and footer describe regions. They also help developers review the page's information architecture.

Links and buttons

Different elements, different promises

A link takes the visitor somewhere. A button performs an action on the current page. Styling does not change their meaning.

Link text

Make the destination clear out of context

Avoid: Click here.

Better: Read the accessibility review checklist.

The visible words should tell a reader where the link goes.

Images as information

Every image needs a role

Decorative images can be ignored. Informative images need alternative text that communicates their purpose in the surrounding context.

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Alternative text

Describe the information, not every pixel

Weak: Image of a person.

Useful: Student tests a website with keyboard navigation on a laptop.

If the caption already says it, alt text can be shorter.

Lists and data

Choose the element that matches the relationship

Use ul for an unordered group, ol for a sequence and table for data with row and column relationships.

A table needs headers

Headers connect values to meaning

```
<table>
  <thead><tr><th>Week</th><th>Topic</th></tr></thead>
  <tbody><tr><td>1</td><td>HTML</td></tr></tbody>
</table>
```

Read code aloud: element, content, relationship and purpose.

Structure before style

CSS should reveal a good document, not rescue a confused one

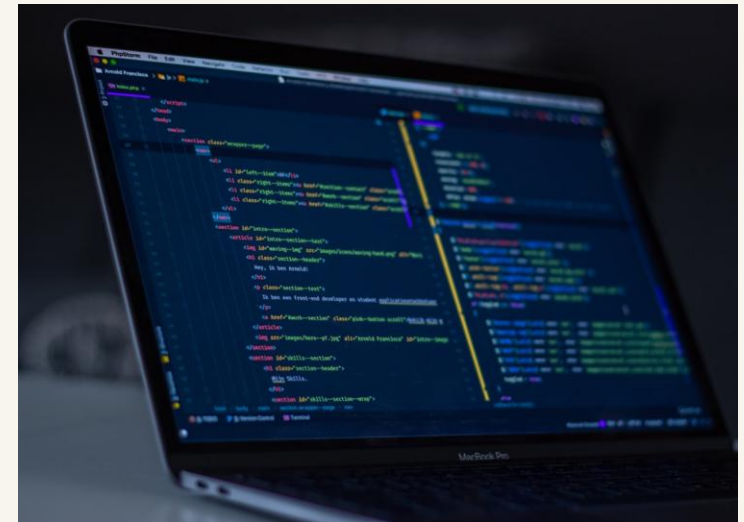
If removing CSS makes the page impossible to understand, revisit the HTML outline first.

Design tokens

Small decisions become a system

**Choose a limited type scale, spacing scale and colour palette.
Reuse them consistently so a reader can recognise hierarchy.**

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Responsive thinking

One document, changing constraints

A narrow screen changes line length, reading order and touch targets. It does not reduce the reader's need for complete information.

A responsive rule

Use CSS to adapt layout, not duplicate content

```
@media (min-width: 48rem) {  
  .feature-list {  
    display: grid;  
    grid-template-columns: repeat(3, 1fr);  
  }  
}
```

Keyboard access

A page should work without a pointer

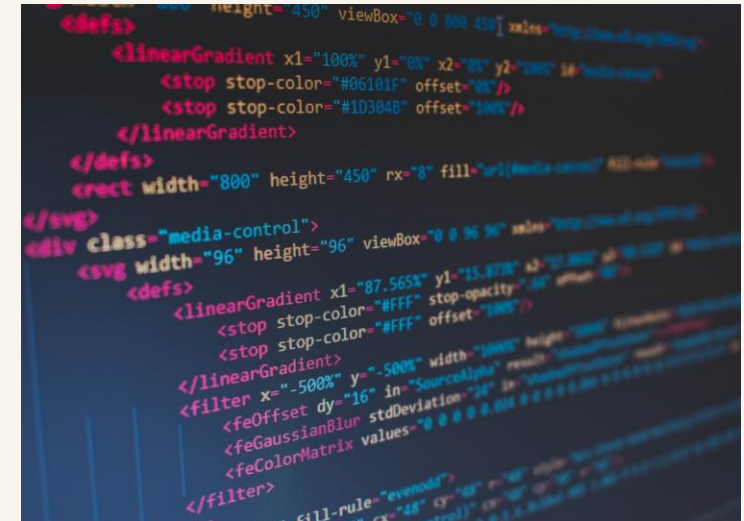
Press Tab. Can you see where focus is? Can you reach every control? Can you activate it and understand the result?

Contrast and hierarchy

Colour alone cannot carry meaning

Use labels, text, position and shape alongside colour. Check contrast in the actual context, including hover and focus states.

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Page inspection

Read the browser's structure

Use browser developer tools to inspect headings, landmarks, link text, image alternatives and the box model.

Question

What evidence would let you judge this page?

Evidence

Name a specific heading, control, label or reading path.

Critical reading exercise

What does this page ask the reader to trust?

Identify the author, purpose, evidence, call to action and missing context. Then describe how the page's structure supports or weakens that trust.

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Studio exercise

Build a reading profile

Choose a useful web page. Recreate its content outline in plain HTML. Do not copy its visual styling. Explain one structural improvement.

Question

What evidence would let you judge this page?

Evidence

Name a specific heading, control, label or reading path.

Quality check

Before you leave today

One h1. Logical h2 sections. Useful links. Images have a role. Keyboard focus is visible. The page still makes sense without CSS.

Question

What evidence would let you judge this page?

Evidence

Name a specific heading, control, label or reading path.

Recommended practice

Continue after class

MDN Learn HTML · W3C WAI accessibility guidance · WebAIM keyboard accessibility · Inspect three sites you use weekly.

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Next week

Semantic HTML in depth

Bring a page you use often and a short written answer: what does the page want you to notice first, and why?

Closing prompt

A web page is an argument about attention

Structure decides what can be found. Design decides what can be noticed. Interaction decides what a visitor can do.